PRESIDENCY DESK · PRIMER

The Agenda Ireland Must Steer

A complete map of every EU security and defence dossier on the Presidency desk — and why Ireland's lanes are maritime surveillance, subsea infrastructure, and cyber resilience, not the domains it lacks.

Security Ireland

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THE THESIS

THE STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE

Ireland's strategic objective for the Presidency is to establish itself as a permanent, credible contributor to European security in the domains where its geography is irreplaceable — maritime surveillance, subsea infrastructure protection, and cyber resilience — so that when the Presidency ends in December 2026, Ireland has locked in a role that outlasts the political window. This is not altruism; a permanent role means Ireland is no longer vulnerable to the free-rider accusation while meaning that EU funding instruments recognise Ireland's contribution. The Presidency is the six-month window in which this can be achieved. This primer maps the full landscape of EU security dossiers on the Presidency desk, explains why these three domains — and not others — are Ireland's natural lanes, and introduces the four Presidency Desk Briefs that operationalise the strategy.

I — The full landscape

Ireland's EU Council Presidency from July to December 2026 coincides with the most consequential period for European defence since the founding of NATO. The European Council is targeting €800 billion in defence investment by 2030; the SAFE loan facility is distributing €150 billion; EDIP is allocating €1.5 billion in grants; the PESCO strategic review is rewriting binding commitments; the EU Hybrid Toolbox has been updated; the next MFF is being framed; military mobility legislation is advancing and capability coalitions are launching concrete projects.

Not all of these are Ireland's business in the same way. Ireland will chair every Council configuration where these dossiers are discussed, but chairing is not the same as leading. Ireland must distinguish between dossiers where it has a credible claim to shape outcomes — because of geographic position, institutional commitments, or economic assets — and dossiers where competent facilitation is the right posture.

This distinction is not a concession, it is a strategy. A Presidency that tries to lead on everything leads on nothing. A Presidency that identifies its lanes and drives hard in them leaves a mark that persists beyond December 2026.

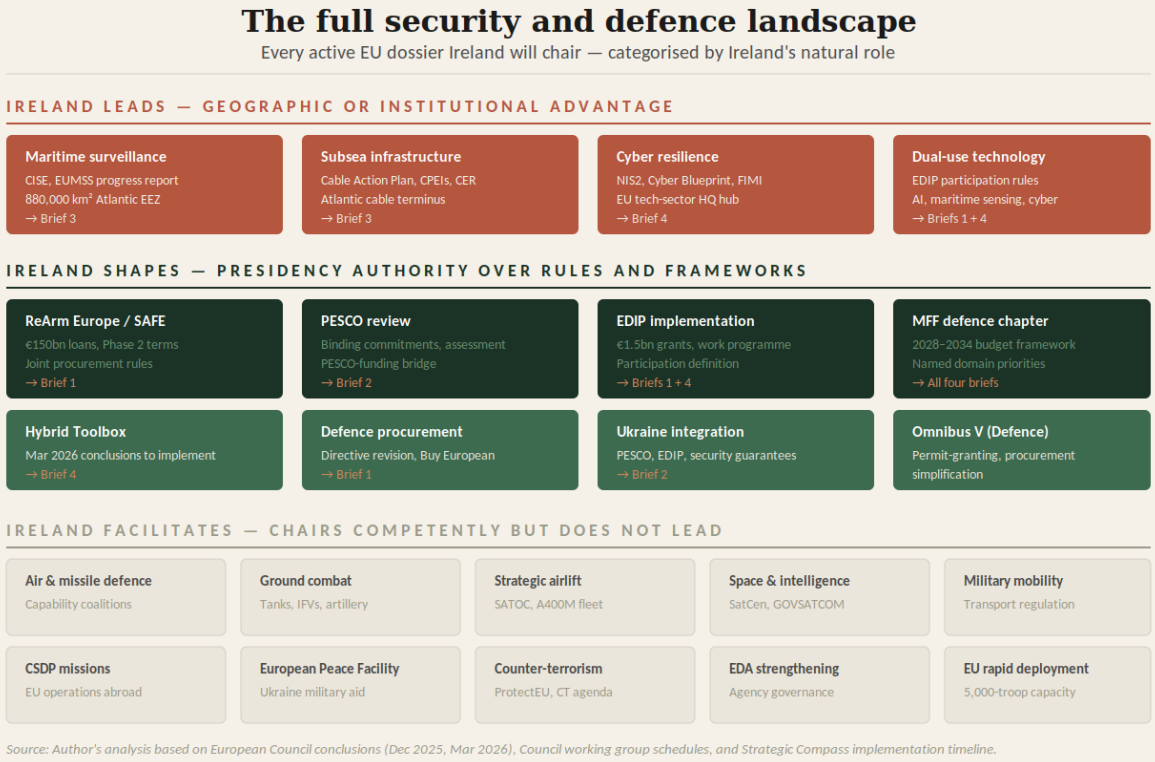

Figure 1: The full security and defence landscape. Every active EU dossier categorised by Ireland's natural role. Terracotta: Ireland leads (geographic or institutional advantage). Forest green: Ireland shapes (Presidency authority over rules). Grey: Ireland facilitates (chairs competently but does not lead). The four Presidency Desk Briefs target the dossiers in the first two categories.

The landscape divides into three categories. In the first, Ireland has a natural leadership position because of geography, institutional commitments, or economic assets that no other EU member state can replicate. Maritime surveillance, subsea infrastructure protection, cyber resilience, and dual-use technology fall here. In the second, Ireland has Presidency authority to shape rules and frameworks through its chair of Council working groups. ReArm Europe, PESCO, EDIP, the MFF defence chapter, the Hybrid Toolbox, defence procurement reform, Ukraine integration, and the Omnibus V defence simplification package fall here. In the third, Ireland will chair dossiers where it has no particular advantage and should facilitate competently: air and missile defence, ground combat, strategic airlift, space, military mobility, CSDP missions, the European Peace Facility, counter-terrorism, EDA governance, and the EU Rapid Deployment Capacity.

The four Presidency Desk Briefs target the first two categories. They do not address air defence, ground combat, or strategic airlift because Ireland has nothing distinctive to contribute to those domains. They do not address counter-terrorism because Ireland's CT posture

is not the subject of EU rule-writing during this term. They address the dossiers where Ireland can shape outcomes — and where failing to shape them has consequences that persist beyond December 2026.

II — Why these three domains

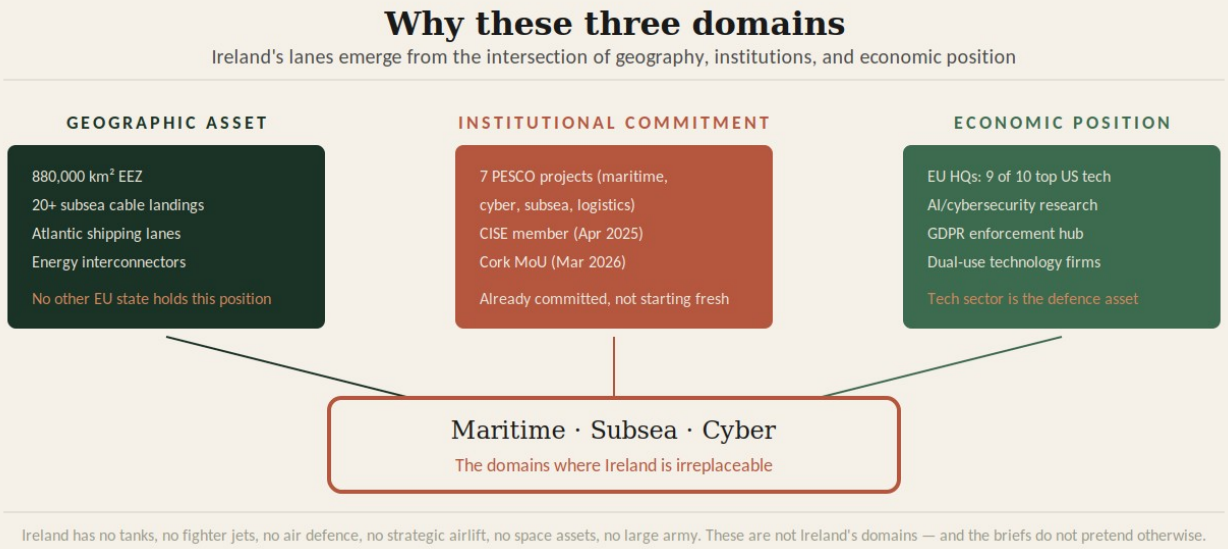

Figure 2: Why maritime, subsea, and cyber. Ireland's three lanes emerge from the intersection of geographic position (Atlantic EEZ, cable terminus), institutional commitments (PESCO projects, CISE, Cork MoU), and economic position (tech-sector headquarters). No other EU member state sits at this intersection.

The three domains are not an arbitrary selection, they emerge from a filter applied to the full landscape: which EU security domains sit at the intersection of Ireland's geographic assets, its existing institutional commitments, and its economic position?

Maritime surveillance

Ireland's 880,000 km² Exclusive Economic Zone is one of Europe's largest. It encompasses Atlantic shipping lanes critical to European trade and waters where Russian submarine activity has increased since 2014. Ireland joined CISE in April 2025 and participates in three PESCO maritime projects. The EUMSS progress report is due during Ireland's chair in October 2026. No other EU state occupies the Atlantic position Ireland holds.

Subsea infrastructure protection

Over twenty subsea cables make landfall on Irish shores, carrying approximately 90 per cent of transatlantic data traffic. The Celtic Interconnector to France arrives in 2027; the Far North Fiber to Alaska, Japan, and Norway is planned for 2026, and the EU Cable Action Plan is investing €1 billion in cable security. Ireland is the western terminus of the transatlantic cable network — this is not a position that can be replicated by another state.

Cyber resilience

Ireland hosts the European headquarters of nine of the ten largest American technology companies. This concentration of digital infrastructure makes Ireland a critical node in the EU's cyber threat surface. A cyber attack on Irish-hosted systems affects data integrity across the entire Union. The 2021 HSE ransomware attack demonstrated the vulnerability. Ireland's PESCO Cyber Threats project and its NCSC (being strengthened) provide the institutional anchor. The government is removing domestic barriers to dual-use technology engagement — but the EU rules must recognise technology contribution for this to matter.

What Ireland does not have

Ireland has no tanks, no fighter jets, no air defence systems, no strategic airlift, no space assets, and no large army. It spends 0.2 per cent of GDP on defence — the lowest in the EU. The four briefs do not pretend otherwise, nor do they argue that Ireland should lead on air and missile defence or ground combat capability. They argue that Ireland should lead in the domains where its assets are irreplaceable and its credibility is built on geography and institutional position, not spending.

III — The Presidency calendar

Figure 3: The Presidency calendar. Security and defence milestones from July to December 2026, organised by dossier. Terracotta markers indicate decision points Ireland can actively shape. Grey markers indicate ongoing processes Ireland chairs.

The calendar shows when each decision falls. The densest period is October–November 2026, when EDIP implementing rules are finalised, the EUMSS progress report is received, PESCO assessment rules are adopted, and cable CPEIs are designated. December is the MFF framework deadline. Ireland must have its positions established before October — the first three months of the Presidency are preparation, the last three are execution.

IV — The four briefs

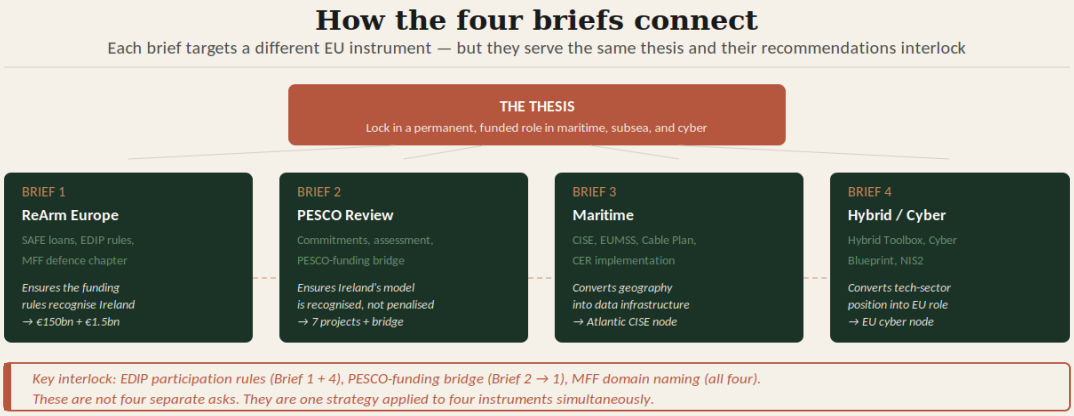

Figure 4: How the four Presidency Desk Briefs connect. Each targets a different EU instrument but serves the same thesis. Key interlocks: EDIP participation rules (Briefs 1 + 4), the PESCO-funding bridge (Brief 2 → 1), and MFF domain naming (all four).

Each brief targets a different EU instrument.

***Brief 1* (ReArm Europe)** addresses the funding rules — SAFE, EDIP, and the MFF defence chapter.

***Brief 2* (PESCO Strategic Review)** addresses the framework that formally recognises Ireland's defence contribution.

***Brief 3* (Maritime Surveillance Cooperation)** addresses the operational infrastructure — CISE, EUMSS, cable protection.

***Brief 4* (Hybrid Threats and Cyber Defence)** addresses the threat-response architecture and Ireland's tech-sector role.

But the briefs are not four separate asks; they are one strategy applied to four instruments simultaneously. EDIP participation rules appear in both *Brief 1* and *Brief*

4 because the same rule determines whether Ireland's tech sector is included or excluded. The PESCO-funding bridge in *Brief 2* only works if *Brief 1*'s recommendation on preferential terms is adopted. The MFF domain naming in all four briefs is the same recommendation applied to different Council working groups. The briefs interlock.

Figure 5: What Ireland brings to each domain. Geography, institutions, and economic position combine to create a credible contribution in each of the three lanes — not aspirational, but grounded in existing assets and commitments.

V — The cost of passive chairing

Every framework being shaped during Ireland's term has a lock-in effect, in that the rules written now persist for years — in some cases a decade — beyond December 2026. SAFE Phase 2 terms set the template for future calls; EDIP participation rules determine Ireland's tech sector inclusion for the programme's lifetime; PESCO binding commitments hold until the next strategic review' CISE architecture, once hardened, determines who provides and who consumes data; the MFF runs to 2034; cable CPEIs are locked for the CEF funding cycle. The Hybrid Toolbox, once operationalised, is the standing framework for EU responses.

This means passive chairing is not neutral, it is a decision with consequences that persist. If Ireland facilitates discussion without shaping rules, the rules are shaped by others — by states with large militaries and defence industries, by states whose interests lie in air defence and ground combat, by states that define contribution through spending rather than geography. The free-rider accusation survives the Presidency. Ireland chairs the largest defence spending programme in EU history and leaves no mark.

The cost of passive chairing

What Ireland loses if it facilitates discussion without shaping rules — across all four instruments

Instrument	What Ireland loses	What persists after Dec 2026
ReArm / SAFE / EDIP	€150bn flows to states with large militaries. Tech sector excluded from EDIP.	Rules persist for a decade. Cannot be reopened until next MFF cycle.
PESCO	Domain-specific model penalised. No PESCO-funding bridge.	Revised commitments bind until next review (2030+).
Maritime / Subsea	Atlantic surveillance led by others. Cable CPEIs exclude Irish routes.	CISE architecture hardened. CPEI list locked for CEF funding cycle.
Hybrid / Cyber	Hybrid toolbox shaped by military states. NCSC remains isolated.	Framework operational. Ireland becomes a consumer, not a shaper.

The free-rider accusation survives the Presidency. Ireland chairs the largest defence programme in EU history and leaves no mark.

Figure 6: The cost of passive chairing, across all four instruments. Each row shows what Ireland loses and what persists beyond December 2026 if it chairs without shaping.

THE BOTTOM LINE

The Presidency is a six-month window. After December 2026, the political attention moves elsewhere. The rules written during Ireland's term will determine whether Ireland's geographic contribution to European security is funded, recognised, and institutionalised — or whether it remains an unfunded vulnerability that others must cover. The *four Presidency Desk Briefs* identify the actions that lock in the permanent role. This primer explains why those actions, and not others, are the right ones.

SERIES OVERVIEW

This primer introduces the Presidency Desk series — four briefs on the EU instruments Ireland must steer during its Council Presidency. Brief 1: ReArm Europe. Brief 2: PESCO Strategic Review. Brief 3: Maritime Surveillance Cooperation. Brief 4: Hybrid Threats and Cyber Defence. Each follows the same structure: why this instrument matters for the thesis, what's being decided during Ireland's term, what Ireland should do, and what happens if Ireland doesn't act. Together, they are one strategy applied to four instruments.